caves similar to those at Barabar, in the adjacent Nagarjuni hill. Like Ashoka again, Dasharatha had these caves excavated for the Ajivikas.[10] They were highly polished chambers, with names like Gopika, Vahiyaka, and Vadathika, created as rainy season shelters: the donative epigraph on the Vahiyaka cave tells us that it ‘has been given by Dasalatha, dear to the gods, to the venerable Ajivikas, immediately on his accession, to be a place of abode during the rainy season as long as the moon and sun shall endure.’

We do not know why Dasharatha chose to follow his grand-father in patronizing the Ajivikas, but his hope that the shelters would serve for them ‘as long as the moon and sun endure’ remained unfulfilled. Subsequently, ‘Ajivikehi’ was the one expression removed or defaced from Maurya epigraphs in the Barabar and Nagarjuni caves, and this selective removal very likely means that the caves were taken over by other religious groups.[11] Since those who chose to so carefully cut out the name of the Ajivikas would have been familiar with the Brahmi script, it is likely that they did so soon after the demise of the Mauryas. In the ensuing centuries, no ruler in North India is known to have provided any kind of patronage to the Ajivikas. There are no inscriptions of any king among the slew of dynasties that followed—the Shungas, Kushanas, and Guptas to name a few—alluding either to the Ajivikas or to donations to them.

On the other hand Buddhism continued to consolidate and prosper, and it was within its religious iconography and texts that parts of Ashoka’s life came to be vividly imaged. The spectacular growth of the religion was visible in the construction and expansion of monumental stupas, viharas, and chaityas. Interestingly, these seem to have depended no longer on the patronage of proactive Buddhist rulers. Instead, common folk from diverse walks of life now made this possible. Sanchi in Central India was one of the places to which Ashoka had been partial, possibly because of his association with Devi: as we saw, he had had a brick stupa constructed and a sandstone pillar put up adjacent to it. This stupa saw a virtual